

A KITCHEN-TABLE GUIDE

# Essential Spanish

*For English-speaking retirees  
living in Panama*

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*You don't need to be fluent. You need to be understood.*

Not a textbook. A practical booklet you can keep on the table,  
open at the farmacia, and sneak a look at in the taxi.

Latin American Spanish · Usted-friendly · Panama examples



Keep it close. Use what you need. Nobody is giving you a quiz.

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*Skip around. The booklet is built for looking things up, not for reading cover to cover.*

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## START HERE

# How to use this booklet

*This is not a school textbook. It is a kitchen-table guide for real life in Panama: the farmacia, the clinic, the mercado, the taxi, and the neighbor who waters your plants when you fly home to see the grandkids.*

Spanish looks like a mountain from far away. Up close, you only need a few paths. This booklet is those paths. Skip around. Dog-ear the pages you actually use. Nobody is giving you a quiz.

## A simple way to use it

- 1 Skim the first half once so the ideas sound familiar.
- 2 Save the web version on your phone. Print the phrase pages if you like paper.
- 3 When you get stuck, flip to the pattern you need — not the whole book.
- 4 Say the sentences out loud. Spanish gets friendlier once your mouth has practiced it.

### If you remember nothing else

Smile. Say **por favor** and **gracias**. Use **usted** with people you don't know well. And the magic phrase: **Más despacio, por favor.** — A little slower, please.

### Panama Spanish, in one paragraph

People here speak Latin American Spanish. They do not use Spain's **vosotros**. The safe word for “you” with strangers, shopkeepers, doctors, and officials is **usted**. Friends may switch to **tú** — follow their lead. And yes, the money is already in dollars. You can skip that particular headache.

### What actually trips English speakers

The splits English does not make are the ones that last: two ways to say “to be” (especially **estar**), two past tenses, and little words like **lo** and **la**. Mixing up **ser** and **estar**, or using the wrong past, is what most often confuses a listener. A wrong **el** or **la** almost never does.

Mistakes are allowed. Panamanians deal with visitors from everywhere, and a kind attempt almost always beats perfect silence. If someone answers you in English, take the help. You can still sneak in a **gracias** on the way out.

## CHAPTER 1

# Fifteen sentences that do a lot of work

*If you only learn one page, make it this one. These sentences will get you through greetings, shops, confusion, and a polite goodbye.*

| Spanish                           | How it sounds                       | English                          |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Hola. Buenos días.</b>         | OH-lah. BWEH-nohs<br>DEE-ahs        | Hi. Good morning.                |
| <b>¿Cómo está usted?</b>          | KOH-moh es-TAH<br>oos-TED           | How are you? (polite)            |
| <b>Me llamo...</b>                | meh YAH-moh                         | My name is...                    |
| <b>Mucho gusto.</b>               | MOO-choh GOO-stoh                   | Nice to meet you.                |
| <b>No hablo español muy bien.</b> | no AH-bloh es-pah-NYOL<br>mwee BYEN | I don't speak Spanish very well. |
| <b>¿Habla inglés?</b>             | AH-blah een-GLEHS                   | Do you speak English?            |
| <b>Más despacio, por favor.</b>   | MAHS des-PAH-syoh por<br>fah-VOR    | A little slower, please.         |
| <b>No entiendo.</b>               | no en-TYEN-doh                      | I don't understand.              |
| <b>¿Puede repetir, por favor?</b> | PWEH-deh reh-peh-TEER               | Can you repeat that, please?     |
| <b>¿Me puede ayudar?</b>          | meh PWEH-deh<br>ah-yoo-DAR          | Can you help me?                 |
| <b>¿Cuánto cuesta?</b>            | KWAHN-toh KWEH-stah                 | How much does it cost?           |
| <b>Quiero esto, por favor.</b>    | KYEH-roh ES-toh por<br>fah-VOR      | I want this, please.             |
| <b>¿Dónde está el baño?</b>       | DOHN-deh es-TAH el<br>BAH-nyoh      | Where is the bathroom?           |
| <b>Me duele aquí.</b>             | meh DWEH-leh ah-KEE                 | It hurts here. (point)           |
| <b>Gracias. Que le vaya bien.</b> | GRAH-syahs. keh leh<br>VAH-yah BYEN | Thank you. Take care.            |

**Pointing is a strategy**

Hold up the thing, the bottle, the address on your phone. **Esto, por favor** (this, please) plus a finger will carry you farther than a perfect verb chart.

**CHAPTER 2**

# How Spanish sounds

*Here is the best news in this whole booklet: Spanish is mostly phonetic. Once the sounds are in your ear, you can read a menu out loud and be close enough.*

## The five vowels never really change

English vowels wander all over the place. Spanish vowels stay home. Learn these five and a lot of words suddenly look readable.

| Letter | Say it like                 | Example      |
|--------|-----------------------------|--------------|
| a      | ah in father                | casa, Panamá |
| e      | eh in bet (clear, not “ay”) | café, mesa   |
| i      | ee in machine               | sí, vino     |
| o      | oh in go, but shorter       | hola, doctor |
| u      | oo in moon                  | tú, uno      |

## The consonants that surprise English speakers

| Letter        | What to do                                               | Example        |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| h             | Always silent.                                           | hola = OH-lah  |
| j             | A strong h, from the throat.                             | José, jardín   |
| ll / y        | In Panama, both sound like y in yes.                     | calle, playa   |
| ñ             | ny, as in canyon.                                        | mañana, señor  |
| r             | A quick tap (like the tt in butter, American-style).     | pero, caro     |
| rr            | A trill. Do your best. People will still understand you. | perro, arroz   |
| v / b         | Almost the same sound. Don't stress the difference.      | vaca, banco    |
| qu            | A k sound. The u is silent.                              | qué, quiero    |
| c + e/i, or z | An s sound in Panama (not the Spanish lisp).             | cielo, cerveza |
| g + e/i       | Same raspy h as j.                                       | gente, giro    |

Two extra spelling notes: **gue** and **gui** have a silent u (**guitarra**). And **qué, cuál, cómo, dónde, cuándo, quién** take an accent when they are questions.

## Where the stress goes

- If there is an accent mark, stress that syllable: **café, teléfono, Panamá**.
- No accent, and the word ends in a vowel, n, or s? Stress the second-to-last syllable: **casa, hablan, lunes**.
- No accent, and it ends in any other consonant? Stress the last syllable: **doctor, hotel, español**.

### Skip the rolled r if you have to

The sound that marks you as English is usually the vowels — keep them short and pure, not “no-uh” or “day-ee.” A weak rolled **rr** almost never blocks meaning. A swallowed vowel sometimes does.

**What your ear will notice here**

Along the coast, a final **s** can sound soft or almost disappear. **Más o menos** might sound like “mah o meno.” You did not go deaf. That is just Panama talking — and it can hide plurals when you listen. In the highlands (Boquete, Volcán, El Valle) speech is often a bit clearer.

**CHAPTER 3**

## El, la, and the idea of gender

*Every Spanish noun is masculine or feminine. There is no secret logic that makes a table masculine and a chair feminine. Learn the little word in front with the noun, the way you learned “a pair of scissors.” English speakers slip here for years — and listeners still understand them.*

|        | Masculine         | Feminine           |
|--------|-------------------|--------------------|
| the    | el (plural: los)  | la (plural: las)   |
| a / an | un (plural: unos) | una (plural: unas) |

A few handy patterns — not rules you must defend in court:

- Words ending in **-o** are usually masculine: **el banco, el mercado, el baño.**
- Words ending in **-a** are usually feminine: **la casa, la farmacia, la cuenta.**
- Words ending in **-ción, -sión, -dad, -tad** are feminine: **la dirección, la ciudad.**
- When in doubt, English speakers default to masculine. The slips that last are almost always on feminine words. Learn **la** with those nouns and you cut the problem in half.

### Professions: el and la tell you who

Some job words don't change at all. The little word in front is the gender: **el** for a man, **la** for a woman. This is the usual pattern for words ending in **-ista**.

|                                            |                                      |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <b>el dentista / la dentista</b>           | <i>the dentist (a man / a woman)</i> |
| <b>el receptionista / la receptionista</b> | <i>the receptionist</i>              |
| <b>el especialista / la especialista</b>   | <i>the specialist</i>                |

Other jobs do change the ending: **el médico / la médica, el vecino / la vecina.** Either way, listen for **el** or **la** — that is who they are.

## Learn these with the article

These are the ones that do not follow the -o / -a hint. Photograph this list.

| Say it this way                     | Why it tricks you                                 |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>el día</b>                       | ends in -a, still masculine                       |
| <b>el mapa</b>                      | ends in -a, still masculine                       |
| <b>el problema / el clima</b>       | the -ma words are usually masculine               |
| <b>el sistema / el programa</b>     | same -ma pattern                                  |
| <b>el agua</b>                      | feminine, but takes el so you don't get “la agua” |
| <b>la mano</b>                      | ends in -o, still feminine                        |
| <b>la foto / la radio / la moto</b> | short for fotografía, etc. — still feminine       |
| <b>el sofá</b>                      | looks like -a; masculine                          |

## Making words plural

| If it ends in... | Do this               | Example                              |
|------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------|
| a vowel          | add s                 | casa to casas, taxi to taxis         |
| a consonant      | add es                | doctor to doctores, hotel to hoteles |
| z                | change z to c, add es | lápiz to lápices                     |

## You'll use these every week

|                                       |                                             |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>el médico / la médica</b>          | <i>the doctor</i>                           |
| <b>la clínica / el hospital</b>       | <i>the clinic / the hospital</i>            |
| <b>la farmacia</b>                    | <i>the pharmacy</i>                         |
| <b>el mercado / el supermercado</b>   | <i>the market / the supermarket</i>         |
| <b>la cuenta</b>                      | <i>the bill (or the account)</i>            |
| <b>el dinero / la plata</b>           | <i>money (plata is the casual word)</i>     |
| <b>el vecino / la vecina</b>          | <i>the neighbor</i>                         |
| <b>el apartamento / la casa</b>       | <i>the apartment / the house</i>            |
| <b>la luz / el agua / el internet</b> | <i>the power / the water / the internet</i> |
| <b>el aire (acondicionado)</b>        | <i>the air conditioning</i>                 |

### Don't wait for perfect gender

If you say **el farmacia** by accident, the pharmacist will still sell you the aspirin. Listeners almost never get lost over a wrong **el** or **la**. Get the noun out. Gender can catch up later.

## CHAPTER 4

# Describing things

*Adjectives have to match the noun: masculine or feminine, singular or plural. And they usually come after the noun, which feels backwards until it doesn't.*

|                              |                           |
|------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>una casa grande</b>       | <i>a big house</i>        |
| <b>un café bueno</b>         | <i>a good coffee</i>      |
| <b>las islas bonitas</b>     | <i>the pretty islands</i> |
| <b>el banco está cerrado</b> | <i>the bank is closed</i> |

If the adjective ends in **-o**, it changes: **alto, alta, altos, altas**. If it ends in **-e** or a consonant, you often only add **s** for plural: **grande** to **grandes**, **fácil** to **fáciles**.

| Spanish                  | English                  |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>bueno / buena</b>     | good                     |
| <b>malo / mala</b>       | bad                      |
| <b>grande</b>            | big                      |
| <b>pequeño / pequeña</b> | small                    |
| <b>caro / cara</b>       | expensive                |
| <b>barato / barata</b>   | cheap                    |
| <b>cerca / lejos</b>     | near / far               |
| <b>caliente / frío</b>   | hot / cold               |
| <b>abierto / cerrado</b> | open / closed            |
| <b>ocupado / libre</b>   | busy or occupied / free  |
| <b>rico / rica</b>       | delicious (food) or rich |
| <b>limpio / sucio</b>    | clean / dirty            |

#### **Bueno likes to jump in front**

You'll hear **un buen médico** and **un mal día**. **Bueno** and **malo** often drop the **-o** and hop in front of a masculine noun. Copy what you hear.

## CHAPTER 5

# I, you, we

Spanish has more words for “you” than English. In Panama the map is simpler than in Spain, and **usted** will keep you out of trouble.

| Spanish                    | English        | When to use it                                              |
|----------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>yo</b>                  | I              | Talking about yourself. Often dropped: <b>Hablo inglés.</b> |
| <b>tú</b>                  | you (friendly) | Friends, once they use tú with you.                         |
| <b>usted</b>               | you (polite)   | Your default. Shops, clinics, new people, anyone older.     |
| <b>él / ella</b>           | he / she       | About someone else.                                         |
| <b>nosotros / nosotras</b> | we             | Nosotras if the group is all women.                         |
| <b>ustedes</b>             | you all        | Any group. Panama does not use vosotros.                    |
| <b>ellos / ellas</b>       | they           | Ellas if the group is all women.                            |

## Usted is not stiff here

In some countries **usted** can sound very formal. In Panama it is everyday respect. Using it with a cashier or a doctor is not cold — it is polite. If a neighbor switches to **tú**, you can switch too.

You will notice people skip **yo** and **tú** a lot. The verb ending already says who is doing the action. **Tengo una cita** is enough. You do not need **Yo tengo una cita** unless you want to emphasize I.

## This, that, these, those

| Near you                     | A little farther    | A thing / idea    |
|------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
| <b>este / esta (this)</b>    | ese / esa (that)    | esto (this thing) |
| <b>estos / estas (these)</b> | esos / esas (those) | eso (that thing)  |

|                                    |                                 |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>¿Cuánto cuesta esto?</b>        | <i>How much is this?</i>        |
| <b>Quiero esa, por favor.</b>      | <i>I want that one, please.</i> |
| <b>Estos son mis medicamentos.</b> | <i>These are my medicines.</i>  |

## CHAPTER 6

## Two ways to say “to be”

English has one “to be.” Spanish has two: **ser** and **estar**. English speakers grab **ser** first and overuse it for years. The work is **estar** — especially for how someone feels and whether something is open, closed, ready, or broken.

### Ser — what something is (this one comes naturally)

Use **ser** for identity, origin, occupation, time, dates, and the stuff something is made of. If it answers “what is it?” or “who is it?”, you probably want **ser**.

|                                                    |                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Soy de Canadá. / Soy de los Estados Unidos.</b> | <i>I'm from Canada. / I'm from the United States.</i> |
| <b>Soy jubilado / jubilada.</b>                    | <i>I'm retired. (that's who you are)</i>              |
| <b>Ella es médica.</b>                             | <i>She is a doctor.</i>                               |
| <b>Somos vecinos.</b>                              | <i>We're neighbors.</i>                               |
| <b>Es el martes. / Son las tres.</b>               | <i>It's Tuesday. / It's three o'clock.</i>            |
| <b>El anillo es de oro.</b>                        | <i>The ring is made of gold.</i>                      |
| <b>¿Quién es? — Es el plomero.</b>                 | <i>Who is it? — It's the plumber.</i>                 |

## Estar — how or where something is (practice this one)

Location is always **estar**, even if the place never moves: **Panamá está en Centroamérica**. Feelings, health, and “how is it right now?” are **estar** too. That last group is the one English speakers keep handing to **ser** by accident.

|                                                          |                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Estoy en David. / Estamos en la capital.</b>          | <i>I'm in David. / We're in Panama City.</i>            |
| <b>¿Cómo está usted? — Estoy bien.</b>                   | <i>How are you? — I'm well.</i>                         |
| <b>Estoy cansado / cansada. Estoy enfermo / enferma.</b> | <i>I'm tired. I'm sick.</i>                             |
| <b>El banco está cerrado. La farmacia está abierta.</b>  | <i>The bank is closed. The pharmacy is open.</i>        |
| <b>El baño está ocupado. / Está listo.</b>               | <i>The bathroom is occupied. / It's ready.</i>          |
| <b>La sopa está caliente. El aire no está frío.</b>      | <i>The soup is hot (right now). The A/C isn't cold.</i> |
| <b>Está lloviendo.</b>                                   | <i>It's raining.</i>                                    |

### The mix-up that actually confuses people

A wrong **el** or **la** rarely blocks meaning. Picking the wrong “to be” often does. **Soy enfermo** sounds like “I am a sick person by nature.” **Estoy enfermo** is “I'm sick (right now).” **Soy jubilado** is your identity. Location, mood, open/closed: **estar**.

| <b>ser</b>                              | <b>estar</b> |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------|
| <b>soy</b>                              | estoy        |
| <b>eres (tú) / es (usted, él, ella)</b> | estás / está |
| <b>somos</b>                            | estamos      |
| <b>son (ustedes, ellos, ellas)</b>      | están        |

### A pocket rule

**Ser** = what it is. **Estar** = how or where it is right now. If you can add “at the moment” in English, try **estar**.

## Hay — there is / there are

One more cousin: **hay** (sounds like “eye”). It means there is or there are. It does not change for plural. Mixing up **hay** with **es** or **está** is another mix-up listeners actually feel.

|                                    |                                               |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Hay un banco cerca.</b>         | <i>There is a bank nearby.</i>                |
| <b>¿Hay una farmacia por aquí?</b> | <i>Is there a pharmacy around here?</i>       |
| <b>No hay problema.</b>            | <i>No problem. (you'll hear this all day)</i> |
| <b>Hay mucha gente.</b>            | <i>There are a lot of people.</i>             |

### Hay vs. está

**Hay un banco en la esquina** introduces it — there is a bank. **El banco está en la esquina** locates a bank you both already have in mind. If you are asking whether something exists nearby, start with **¿Hay...?**

## CHAPTER 7

# Right now: the present tense

*If you get comfortable in the present, you can handle most of a regular day. Tomorrow and yesterday can piggyback on it, as you'll see in a few chapters.*

Spanish verbs in the dictionary end in **-ar**, **-er**, or **-ir**. You knock that ending off and add a new one. **Usted** uses the same ending as he/she. **Ustedes** uses the same ending as they. That cuts the chart almost in half.

## hablar — to speak

| Person                  | Form     |
|-------------------------|----------|
| yo                      | hablo    |
| tú                      | hablas   |
| usted / él / ella       | habla    |
| nosotros                | hablamos |
| ustedes / ellos / ellas | hablan   |

## comer — to eat • vivir — to live

| Person            | comer   | vivir   |
|-------------------|---------|---------|
| yo                | como    | vivo    |
| tú                | comes   | vives   |
| usted / él / ella | come    | vive    |
| nosotros          | comemos | vivimos |
| ustedes / ellos   | comen   | viven   |

|                                  |                                      |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <b>Hablo un poco de español.</b> | <i>I speak a little Spanish.</i>     |
| <b>¿Habla inglés?</b>            | <i>Do you speak English? (usted)</i> |
| <b>Vivimos en Coronado.</b>      | <i>We live in Coronado.</i>          |
| <b>Ellos comen a las dos.</b>    | <i>They eat at two.</i>              |

The present also covers things you do in general, not only this second: **Tomo café por la mañana.** I drink coffee in the morning.

### Need a verb in a hurry?

You can often skip conjugating altogether: **Quiero + a verb, Necesito + a verb, Voy a + a verb.** Chapter 10 is built on that trick.

## CHAPTER 8

# The verbs you'll live on

*A short list of slightly irregular verbs does more daily work than twenty perfectly regular ones. Learn these in the present and you will hear them everywhere.*

| Infinitive                      | yo     | usted / él / ella | nosotros | ustedes |
|---------------------------------|--------|-------------------|----------|---------|
| <b>ser (to be)</b>              | soy    | es                | somos    | son     |
| <b>estar (to be)</b>            | estoy  | está              | estamos  | están   |
| <b>ir (to go)</b>               | voy    | va                | vamos    | van     |
| <b>tener (to have)</b>          | tengo  | tiene             | tenemos  | tienen  |
| <b>hacer (to do / make)</b>     | hago   | hace              | hacemos  | hacen   |
| <b>poder (to be able / can)</b> | puedo  | puede             | podemos  | pueden  |
| <b>querer (to want)</b>         | quiero | quiere            | queremos | quieren |
| <b>decir (to say / tell)</b>    | digo   | dice              | decimos  | dicen   |
| <b>venir (to come)</b>          | vengo  | viene             | venimos  | vienen  |
| <b>dar (to give)</b>            | doy    | da                | damos    | dan     |
| <b>ver (to see)</b>             | veo    | ve                | vemos    | ven     |
| <b>saber (to know a fact)</b>   | sé     | sabe              | sabemos  | saben   |

The **tú** forms (if a friend is using tú with you) usually look like the usted form plus an **s**: **vas, tienes, puedes, quieres**. Exceptions you already know: **eres, estás**.

## Tener is bigger than “to have”

English says “I am hungry.” Spanish says “I have hunger.” Copy these as chunks.

|                                   |                                      |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <b>Tengo hambre. / Tengo sed.</b> | <i>I'm hungry. / I'm thirsty.</i>    |
| <b>Tengo calor. / Tengo frío.</b> | <i>I'm hot. / I'm cold.</i>          |
| <b>Tengo sueño.</b>               | <i>I'm sleepy.</i>                   |
| <b>Tengo X años.</b>              | <i>I am X years old.</i>             |
| <b>Tengo una cita a las diez.</b> | <i>I have an appointment at ten.</i> |
| <b>¿Tiene cambio?</b>             | <i>Do you have change?</i>           |

## Saber vs. conocer — two kinds of knowing

|                                      |                                                                |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>¿Sabe dónde está el hospital?</b> | <i>Do you know where the hospital is? (a fact)</i>             |
| <b>No sé.</b>                        | <i>I don't know.</i>                                           |
| <b>¿Conoce a un buen dentista?</b>   | <i>Do you know a good dentist? (are you familiar with one)</i> |
| <b>Conocemos Boquete.</b>            | <i>We know Boquete. (we've been there)</i>                     |

### Hace calor — and then some

Weather uses **hacer**: **Hace calor. Hace sol. Está lloviendo.** In Panama, **verano** is the dry season (roughly December to April) and **invierno** is the rainy season. Nobody here is talking about snow.

## CHAPTER 9

# I like it — the gustar twist

**Gustar** is not “I like.” It is closer to “it is pleasing to me.” That is why the verb agrees with the thing you like, not with you. Weird for about a week. Then it clicks.

|                                 |                                           |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>Me gusta el café.</b>        | <i>I like coffee. (one thing: gusta)</i>  |
| <b>Me gustan las empanadas.</b> | <i>I like empanadas. (plural: gustan)</i> |
| <b>No me gusta el ruido.</b>    | <i>I don't like the noise.</i>            |
| <b>¿Le gusta el pescado?</b>    | <i>Do you like fish? (usted)</i>          |
| <b>Nos gusta Panamá.</b>        | <i>We like Panama.</i>                    |

| Word       | English                          |
|------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>me</b>  | to me                            |
| <b>te</b>  | to you (tú)                      |
| <b>le</b>  | to you (usted) / to him / to her |
| <b>nos</b> | to us                            |
| <b>les</b> | to you all / to them             |

Want to make it extra clear? Add a phrase up front: **A mí me gusta...** **A usted le gusta...** You'll hear that a lot when people contrast tastes.

## Don't say yo gusto

English wants “I like.” Spanish will not take **Yo gusto el café.** Start with **me**: **Me gusta el café.** Same family: **Me duele aquí. Me encanta este lugar. Me falta dinero.**

Love it? Same pattern: **Me encanta este lugar. Me encantan las islas.** That is the friendly way to say “I love it” about food, towns, and weather — not usually about people. For people, **Quiero mucho a...** is safer.

## CHAPTER 10

# Questions, “no,” and the magic five

You can live a long time on questions, a well-placed **no**, and five little helper verbs. This chapter is the Swiss Army knife.

## Asking questions

Written Spanish uses two question marks: **¿ ... ?** Spoken Spanish often just uses tone. You can turn many statements into questions by lifting your voice: **¿Habla inglés?**

| Word                     | English               | Try this                |
|--------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|
| <b>qué</b>               | what                  | ¿Qué es esto?           |
| <b>quién</b>             | who                   | ¿Quién es?              |
| <b>dónde</b>             | where                 | ¿Dónde está el baño?    |
| <b>cuándo</b>            | when                  | ¿Cuándo abre?           |
| <b>cómo</b>              | how                   | ¿Cómo está usted?       |
| <b>cuánto / cuánta</b>   | how much              | ¿Cuánto cuesta?         |
| <b>cuántos / cuántas</b> | how many              | ¿Cuántos años tiene?    |
| <b>por qué</b>           | why                   | ¿Por qué está cerrado?  |
| <b>cuál</b>              | which / what (choice) | ¿Cuál es su dirección?  |
| <b>a qué hora</b>        | at what time          | ¿A qué hora es la cita? |

## Saying no

Put **no** right before the verb: **No hablo español muy bien.** Double negatives are correct, not sloppy: **No tengo nada.** (I don't have anything.) **No hay nadie.** (There's no one.)

|                     |                            |
|---------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>No entiendo.</b> | <i>I don't understand.</i> |
| <b>No sé.</b>       | <i>I don't know.</i>       |
| <b>No, gracias.</b> | <i>No, thank you.</i>      |
| <b>Todavía no.</b>  | <i>Not yet.</i>            |

## The magic five: want, can, need, have to, going to

Park a verb in its dictionary form after one of these, and you can talk about almost any action without conjugating the second verb. This is the cheat that fluent-looking beginners actually use.

| Pattern                   | Example                        | English                       |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b>Quiero + verb</b>      | Quiero pagar.                  | I want to pay.                |
| <b>Puedo / ¿Puede...?</b> | ¿Puede ayudarme?               | Can you help me?              |
| <b>Necesito + verb</b>    | Necesito hablar con el médico. | I need to talk to the doctor. |
| <b>Tengo que + verb</b>   | Tengo que ir al banco.         | I have to go to the bank.     |
| <b>Voy a + verb</b>       | Voy a llamar mañana.           | I'm going to call tomorrow.   |

|                                           |                                                |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Quiero reservar una mesa.</b>          | <i>I want to reserve a table.</i>              |
| <b>No puedo caminar mucho.</b>            | <i>I can't walk very far.</i>                  |
| <b>Necesito un taxi.</b>                  | <i>I need a taxi.</i>                          |
| <b>Tenemos que esperar.</b>               | <i>We have to wait.</i>                        |
| <b>Vamos a comer aquí.</b>                | <i>We're going to eat here.</i>                |
| <b>¿Me puede escribir eso, por favor?</b> | <i>Can you write that down for me, please?</i> |

### Your future tense, for now

Spanish has a “real” future tense (**hablaré, irá**). You can ignore it for months. **Voy a...** is what people actually say about later today, tomorrow, and next Tuesday.

## CHAPTER 11

# Yesterday, without the headache

*Spanish has two everyday past tenses. English has one. That is why this chapter lasts for years. You need a snapshot version: one past for finished events, one past for background and “used to.” The English trap is using the snapshot past for both.*

## The snapshot: something finished

Use this when the thing happened and it's done. Yesterday. This morning. Last Tuesday. A completed trip to the clinic.

|                             |                                        |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Ayer fui al médico.</b>  | <i>Yesterday I went to the doctor.</i> |
| <b>Comí pescado.</b>        | <i>I ate fish.</i>                     |
| <b>Pagamos en efectivo.</b> | <i>We paid in cash.</i>                |
| <b>¿Qué pasó?</b>           | <i>What happened?</i>                  |

A few high-value “I / he-she-you” forms:

| Verb                            | yo     | usted / él / ella |
|---------------------------------|--------|-------------------|
| <b>ir / ser (to go / to be)</b> | fui    | fue               |
| <b>estar</b>                    | estuve | estuvo            |
| <b>tener</b>                    | tuve   | tuvo              |
| <b>hacer</b>                    | hice   | hizo              |
| <b>decir</b>                    | dije   | dijo              |
| <b>venir</b>                    | vine   | vino              |
| <b>ver</b>                      | vi     | vio               |
| <b>poder</b>                    | pude   | pudo              |
| <b>dar</b>                      | di     | dio               |
| <b>hablar (regular -ar)</b>     | hablé  | habló             |
| <b>comer (regular -er)</b>      | comí   | comió             |

## The background: how things were

Use this for weather, age, feelings, what something used to be like, or what was going on around the main event.

|                                      |                                                   |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Hacía mucho calor.</b>            | <i>It was really hot.</i>                         |
| <b>Cuando vivíamos en Florida...</b> | <i>When we used to live in Florida...</i>         |
| <b>Era médico.</b>                   | <i>He was a doctor. (that was his profession)</i> |
| <b>Estaba cansada.</b>               | <i>She was tired.</i>                             |
| <b>Había mucha gente.</b>            | <i>There were a lot of people.</i>                |

| Useful background forms | English                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>era / eran</b>       | was / were (ser)          |
| <b>estaba / estaban</b> | was / were (estar)        |
| <b>había</b>            | there was / there were    |
| <b>tenía</b>            | had / used to have        |
| <b>hacía</b>            | was making / weather was  |
| <b>iba</b>              | was going / used to go    |
| <b>vivía</b>            | used to live / was living |

## The English trap

If you can add “used to” or “was ...-ing” in English, do not use the snapshot past. **Comí pescado** is “I ate fish (and I was done).” **Comía pescado** is “I used to eat fish / I was eating fish.” English speakers keep putting the snapshot where the background belongs. Listeners feel that one.

|                                                |                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ayer comí pescado.</b>                      | <i>Yesterday I ate fish. (done)</i>                  |
| <b>Cuando vivía en Florida, comía pescado.</b> | <i>When I lived in Florida, I used to eat fish.</i>  |
| <b>Fui al médico el martes.</b>                | <i>I went to the doctor on Tuesday. (that visit)</i> |
| <b>Iba al médico cada mes.</b>                 | <i>I used to go to the doctor every month.</i>       |

**If you freeze, tell the story in two strokes**

Background first, snapshot second: **Estaba en la casa y se fue la luz.** I was at the house and the power went out. That pattern will carry a lot of stories.

**CHAPTER 12**

## Please do this: commands

*You don't need the full command system. You need a short list for clinics, shops, and friends. Use the **usted** column with people you don't know well. Use the **tú** column once someone is using tú with you.*

| Formal (usted)        | Informal (tú)         | English                 |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|
| Deme..., por favor.   | Dame..., por favor.   | Give me..., please.     |
| Tráigame la cuenta.   | Tráeme la cuenta.     | Bring me the bill.      |
| Ayúdeme, por favor.   | Ayúdame, por favor.   | Help me, please.        |
| Espere un momento.    | Espera un momento.    | Wait a moment.          |
| Pase, por favor.      | Pasa, por favor.      | Come in, please.        |
| Sígame, por favor.    | Sígueme, por favor.   | Follow me, please.      |
| Hable más despacio.   | Habla más despacio.   | Speak more slowly.      |
| Escríbalo, por favor. | Escríbelo, por favor. | Write it down, please.  |
| Perdóneme.            | Perdóname.            | Excuse me / forgive me. |
| Dígame.               | Dime.                 | Tell me.                |

You'll hear these said to you:

| Formal (usted)       | Informal (tú)        | English                    |
|----------------------|----------------------|----------------------------|
| Tome asiento.        | Toma asiento.        | Have a seat.               |
| Firme aquí.          | Firma aquí.          | Sign here.                 |
| Espere aquí.         | Espera aquí.         | Wait here.                 |
| Pase a la caja.      | Pasa a la caja.      | Go to the cashier.         |
| No fume.             | No fumes.            | No smoking. / Don't smoke. |
| Siéntese, por favor. | Siéntate, por favor. | Please sit down.           |

### How they're built, if you're curious

**Usted:** start with the **yo** form in the present, drop the **-o**, and add the “opposite” vowel — **hablo** to **hable**, **como** to **coma**, **vivo** to **viva**. Rebels: **tenga, venga, diga, haga, ponga, vaya, sea, esté, dé**. **Tú** yes-commands are usually the he/she present: **habla, come, vive**. Rebels: **di, haz, ve, pon, sal, sé, ten, ven**. **Tú** no-commands look like usted plus an **s**: **no fumes, no hables**.

### Regálame un vaso de agua

You will hear **regalar** used for “hand me / give me,” not only for birthday presents. **¿Me regala una bolsa?** is a normal way to ask for a bag at the checkout. With a friend: **Regálame una bolsa**. They are not asking you to donate one.

## CHAPTER 13

# Por and para — the short version

*Both can translate as “for,” which is unhelpful. You do not need every textbook list. You need two jobs for **para** and three jobs for **por**.*

## Para — purpose, destination, deadline, recipient

|                                  |                                             |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Este café es para usted.         | <i>This coffee is for you.</i>              |
| Salimos para Boquete el viernes. | <i>We're leaving for Boquete on Friday.</i> |
| Lo necesito para mañana.         | <i>I need it by tomorrow.</i>               |
| Estudio para hablar mejor.       | <i>I study in order to speak better.</i>    |

## Por — reason, duration, through, exchange

|                                                    |                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>Gracias por su ayuda.</b>                       | <i>Thank you for your help.</i>             |
| <b>Caminamos por la playa.</b>                     | <i>We walked along the beach.</i>           |
| <b>Estuve allí por tres días.</b>                  | <i>I was there for three days.</i>          |
| <b>Pagué diez dólares por esto.</b>                | <i>I paid ten dollars for this.</i>         |
| <b>Por la mañana / por la tarde / por la noche</b> | <i>in the morning / afternoon / evening</i> |

### Stuck?

If it means “in order to,” “by this date,” “headed to,” or “this is for that person,” try **para**. If it means “because of,” “through,” “for a stretch of time,” or “in exchange for,” try **por**. And memorize **por favor** as a chunk. Do not take it apart.

## CHAPTER 14

# Where things are

Location is **estar** plus a little preposition. Learn the cluster below and you can follow directions — or give them with your hands.

| Spanish                              | English                     |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| <b>en</b>                            | in / on / at                |
| <b>a</b>                             | to / at (with motion: ir a) |
| <b>de</b>                            | of / from                   |
| <b>con / sin</b>                     | with / without              |
| <b>cerca de / lejos de</b>           | near / far from             |
| <b>al lado de</b>                    | next to                     |
| <b>delante de / detrás de</b>        | in front of / behind        |
| <b>encima de / debajo de</b>         | on top of / under           |
| <b>dentro de / fuera de</b>          | inside / outside            |
| <b>entre</b>                         | between                     |
| <b>a la derecha / a la izquierda</b> | to the right / to the left  |
| <b>todo recto / derecho</b>          | straight ahead              |

Two fusions you'll see constantly: **a + el = al** (**Voy al banco**) and **de + el = del** (**cerca del hospital**). **A la** and **de la** stay as two words.

|                                                |                                             |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| <b>El banco está al lado del supermercado.</b> | <i>The bank is next to the supermarket.</i> |
| <b>Vivo cerca de la playa.</b>                 | <i>I live near the beach.</i>               |
| <b>Está a dos cuadras.</b>                     | <i>It's two blocks away.</i>                |
| <b>Gire a la derecha.</b>                      | <i>Turn right.</i>                          |
| <b>Venimos de la capital.</b>                  | <i>We came from Panama City.</i>            |

## The personal “a” — when the object is a person

English speakers drop this constantly. It is a tiny **a** before a person (or a pet you treat like a person). Things do not get it. People will still understand you without it. Copy it when you can and you will sound less like a textbook in reverse.

|                                    |                                                       |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Busco a mi esposa.</b>          | <i>I'm looking for my wife.</i>                       |
| <b>Busco un restaurante.</b>       | <i>I'm looking for a restaurant. (a thing — no a)</i> |
| <b>¿Conoce a un buen dentista?</b> | <i>Do you know a good dentist?</i>                    |
| <b>Llamo a María.</b>              | <i>I'm calling María.</i>                             |
| <b>Veo el banco.</b>               | <i>I see the bank. (a thing — no a)</i>               |
| <b>Quiero mucho a mi familia.</b>  | <i>I love my family a lot.</i>                        |

### CHAPTER 15

## Numbers, money, and time

*This is the chapter you will use at the caja, the clinic window, and the taxi door. Panama uses U.S. dollars, so the only conversion is the words.*

### Numbers you actually need

|                       |                       |                     |                            |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>0 cero</b>         | <b>1 uno</b>          | <b>2 dos</b>        | <b>3 tres</b>              |
| <b>4 cuatro</b>       | <b>5 cinco</b>        | <b>6 seis</b>       | <b>7 siete</b>             |
| <b>8 ocho</b>         | <b>9 nueve</b>        | <b>10 diez</b>      | <b>11 once</b>             |
| <b>12 doce</b>        | <b>13 trece</b>       | <b>14 catorce</b>   | <b>15 quince</b>           |
| <b>16 dieciséis</b>   | <b>17 diecisiete</b>  | <b>18 dieciocho</b> | <b>19 diecinueve</b>       |
| <b>20 veinte</b>      | <b>21 veintiuno</b>   | <b>22 veintidós</b> | <b>30 treinta</b>          |
| <b>40 cuarenta</b>    | <b>50 cincuenta</b>   | <b>60 sesenta</b>   | <b>70 setenta</b>          |
| <b>80 ochenta</b>     | <b>90 noventa</b>     | <b>100 cien</b>     | <b>101 ciento uno</b>      |
| <b>200 doscientos</b> | <b>500 quinientos</b> | <b>1,000 mil</b>    | <b>1,000,000 un millón</b> |

- **Uno** becomes **un** before a masculine noun: **un dólar**. **Una** before feminine: **una caja**.
- 200–900 change for gender: **doscientos dólares**, **doscientas cajas**.
- Years: 2026 is **dos mil veintiséis**.

## Money

|                                      |                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>¿Cuánto cuesta? / ¿Cuánto es?</b> | <i>How much does it cost? / How much is it?</i>      |
| <b>¿A cómo?</b>                      | <i>How much each? (at markets)</i>                   |
| <b>Está muy caro.</b>                | <i>That's very expensive.</i>                        |
| <b>¿Me puede hacer un precio?</b>    | <i>Can you do a better price?</i>                    |
| <b>La cuenta, por favor.</b>         | <i>The bill, please.</i>                             |
| <b>¿Tiene cambio? / el vuelto</b>    | <i>Do you have change? / the change you get back</i> |
| <b>en efectivo / con tarjeta</b>     | <i>in cash / by card</i>                             |
| <b>¿Aceptan tarjeta?</b>             | <i>Do you take cards?</i>                            |

### Dollars, balboas, and the caja

Paper money is the U.S. dollar. Local coins are often called **balboas**, but they are worth the same as U.S. coins. **La caja** is the cashier. **La cola** is the line. Tipping is modest — ten percent at sit-down restaurants is a kind default if service is not already included.

## What time is it?

|                                 |                                               |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>¿Qué hora es?</b>            | <i>What time is it?</i>                       |
| <b>Es la una.</b>               | <i>It's one o'clock. (la una is singular)</i> |
| <b>Son las dos.</b>             | <i>It's two o'clock.</i>                      |
| <b>Son las tres y media.</b>    | <i>It's 3:30.</i>                             |
| <b>Son las cuatro y cuarto.</b> | <i>It's 4:15.</i>                             |
| <b>Son las diez menos diez.</b> | <i>It's 9:50. (ten to ten)</i>                |
| <b>a las nueve de la mañana</b> | <i>at 9:00 a.m.</i>                           |
| <b>a las siete de la noche</b>  | <i>at 7:00 p.m.</i>                           |

Days: **lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo**. They are not capitalized. **El lunes** means on Monday; **los lunes** means on Mondays in general.

Months: **enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre.** Dates go day first: **el 9 de septiembre.**

## CHAPTER 16

# Little words that do a lot of work

*These are the glue. If you recognize them, whole sentences stop being a blur.*

| Spanish                         | English                      | Note                                                                    |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>ya</b>                       | already / now                | Also used as “okay, got it.”                                            |
| <b>todavía / aún</b>            | still / yet                  | <b>Todavía no</b> = not yet.                                            |
| <b>también</b>                  | also / too                   |                                                                         |
| <b>tampoco</b>                  | neither / not either         | The “no” version of también.                                            |
| <b>muy / mucho</b>              | very / a lot                 | Muy + adjective: <b>muy caro</b> . Mucho + noun: <b>mucho tráfico</b> . |
| <b>más / menos</b>              | more / less                  | <b>Más espacio. Menos hielo.</b>                                        |
| <b>ahora / ahorita</b>          | now / in a bit               | Ahorita is famously flexible.                                           |
| <b>después / luego</b>          | after / later                |                                                                         |
| <b>aquí / allí / allá</b>       | here / there / over there    |                                                                         |
| <b>bien / mal</b>               | well / badly                 | ¿Todo bien?                                                             |
| <b>hoy / mañana / ayer</b>      | today / tomorrow / yesterday | Mañana is also “morning.”                                               |
| <b>pero / porque / entonces</b> | but / because / so then      |                                                                         |
| <b>siempre / nunca</b>          | always / never               | Nunca already includes the no.                                          |
| <b>casi</b>                     | almost                       | <b>Casi nunca</b> = hardly ever.                                        |

### Ahorita is a lifestyle

**Ahorita** can mean right now, in a few minutes, or later this afternoon, depending on the smile that comes with it. If you need a real time, ask: **¿A qué hora, más o menos?** Around what time?

## A few tiny extras you'll hear constantly

- **-ito / -ita** makes things smaller or kinder: **momentito, cafecito, abuelita**. It is friendly, not baby talk.

- **lo** and **la** often mean “it” or “him/her,” and they sit in front of the verb: **¿Lo vio?** Did you see it? **La tengo.** I have it. If that throws you, just repeat the noun. English speakers trip here more than on verbs — recognition first is enough.
- You'll hear **se lo** a lot: **Se lo dije.** I told him/her it. You do not have to build this yet. Just know it is not a new verb.
- **se** also shows up on signs: **Se vende. Se alquila. Se habla español.** For sale. For rent. Spanish spoken here.
- **Me llamo** is technically a reflexive verb. So is **Me siento mal** (I feel bad). Learn them as phrases.

## CHAPTER 17

# Panama Spanish, the local layer

*You do not need slang to buy papayas. But a few local habits will make the country sound less like your textbook and more like the taxi.*

| You'll hear                    | What they mean                                             |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>la capital</b>              | Panama City                                                |
| <b>el interior</b>             | the rest of the country, outside the city                  |
| <b>chévere</b>                 | great, cool, nice                                          |
| <b>¿Qué xopá?</b>              | What's up? (very Panama; you can just smile back)          |
| <b>pelao / pelaíta</b>         | kid / young person                                         |
| <b>la plata</b>                | money                                                      |
| <b>un chance</b>               | a ride (¿Me da un chance?)                                 |
| <b>la bomba</b>                | the gas station (yes, also “bomb” — context will save you) |
| <b>el abanico</b>              | the fan                                                    |
| <b>la chitra</b>               | no-see-ums, the tiny biting bugs                           |
| <b>diablo rojo</b>             | the old painted buses                                      |
| <b>el Metro / Metrobus</b>     | Panama City's subway and bus system                        |
| <b>farmacia de turno</b>       | the pharmacy on duty that night                            |
| <b>se fue la luz / el agua</b> | the power / water went out                                 |
| <b>¡Juega viva!</b>            | stay sharp / watch out (friendly warning)                  |

- There is no **vos** here (that's more Costa Rica, Nicaragua, Argentina). Stick with **tú** and **usted**.
- There is no **vosotros**. Groups are **ustedes**.
- **Guagua** is not the Panama word for bus. Say **bus**.
- English sneaks in: **el parking, el mall, el email, okay**. You are allowed to mix a little.
- People may answer your careful Spanish with English. That is kindness, not a correction.

## A note you can leave for the building manager

Estimado señor / Estimada señora:

Soy su vecino/a del apartamento \_\_\_\_\_. Se fue el agua esta mañana (or: El aire no funciona / Hay una gotera en el techo). ¿Puede ayudarnos, por favor?

Muchas gracias,

\_\_\_\_\_

## CHAPTER 18

# Phrasebook for a regular week

*Keep this chapter on your phone. Read the Spanish out loud once before you walk in. Close enough is plenty.*

## Greetings and good manners

| Spanish                                               | English                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Buenos días. / Buenas tardes. / Buenas noches.</b> | Good morning. / Good afternoon. / Good evening.   |
| <b>¿Cómo está usted? — Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted?</b>   | How are you? — Fine, thanks. And you?             |
| <b>Mucho gusto. / El gusto es mío.</b>                | Nice to meet you. / The pleasure is mine.         |
| <b>¿Cómo se llama? — Me llamo...</b>                  | What's your name? — My name is...                 |
| <b>Con permiso. / Perdón.</b>                         | Excuse me (passing through). / Sorry / pardon me. |
| <b>Por favor. / Gracias. / De nada.</b>               | Please. / Thank you. / You're welcome.            |
| <b>Hasta luego. / Nos vemos. / Que le vaya bien.</b>  | See you later. / See you. / Take care.            |

## When the Spanish is too fast

| Spanish                                                | English                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>No hablo español muy bien.</b>                      | I don't speak Spanish very well.                     |
| <b>¿Habla inglés?</b>                                  | Do you speak English?                                |
| <b>Más despacio, por favor.</b>                        | More slowly, please.                                 |
| <b>¿Puede repetir?</b>                                 | Can you repeat that?                                 |
| <b>¿Cómo se dice ... en español?</b>                   | How do you say ... in Spanish?                       |
| <b>¿Qué significa esto?</b>                            | What does this mean?                                 |
| <b>¿Me lo puede escribir?</b>                          | Can you write it down for me?                        |
| <b>Un momento, por favor. Voy a usar el traductor.</b> | One moment, please. I'm going to use the translator. |

## At the clinic

| Spanish                                                | English                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tengo una cita a las diez.</b>                      | I have a ten o'clock appointment.              |
| <b>Me duele aquí. / Me duele la cabeza.</b>            | It hurts here. / I have a headache.            |
| <b>Me duele el estómago / la espalda / la rodilla.</b> | My stomach / back / knee hurts.                |
| <b>Tengo mareos / fiebre / tos / náuseas.</b>          | I have dizziness / a fever / a cough / nausea. |
| <b>Me siento mareado/a. / Me siento mal.</b>           | I feel dizzy. / I feel unwell.                 |
| <b>Soy alérgico/a a la penicilina.</b>                 | I'm allergic to penicillin.                    |
| <b>Tomo estos medicamentos. (show the list)</b>        | I take these medications.                      |
| <b>Tengo presión alta / diabetes.</b>                  | I have high blood pressure / diabetes.         |
| <b>Soy jubilado/a.</b>                                 | I'm retired.                                   |
| <b>¿Es grave? / ¿Qué tengo?</b>                        | Is it serious? / What do I have?               |
| <b>¿Cuándo vuelvo?</b>                                 | When do I come back?                           |

## At the pharmacy

| Spanish                                                       | English                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>¿Tiene algo para el dolor / el resfriado / la alergia?</b> | Do you have something for pain / a cold / allergies? |
| <b>Necesito esto. (show paper or bottle)</b>                  | I need this.                                         |
| <b>¿Es con receta?</b>                                        | Is it by prescription?                               |
| <b>Una caja, por favor.</b>                                   | One box, please.                                     |
| <b>¿Cómo se toma?</b>                                         | How do you take it?                                  |
| <b>¿Cada cuántas horas?</b>                                   | Every how many hours?                                |
| <b>Con comida / con el estómago vacío.</b>                    | With food / on an empty stomach.                     |

## Eating out

| Spanish                                                | English                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| <b>Una mesa para dos, por favor.</b>                   | A table for two, please.                 |
| <b>El menú, por favor.</b>                             | The menu, please.                        |
| <b>¿Qué recomienda?</b>                                | What do you recommend?                   |
| <b>Agua sin gas / con gas. Sin hielo, por favor.</b>   | Still / sparkling water. No ice, please. |
| <b>No picante, por favor.</b>                          | Not spicy, please.                       |
| <b>Está delicioso.</b>                                 | It's delicious.                          |
| <b>Para llevar.</b>                                    | To go.                                   |
| <b>La cuenta, por favor.</b>                           | The bill, please.                        |
| <b>¿Propina incluida? / ¿Está incluida la propina?</b> | Is the tip included?                     |

## At home with a plumber, electrician, or gardener

| Spanish                                       | English                                |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Se fue la luz / el agua / el internet.</b> | The power / water / internet went out. |
| <b>El aire no enfría.</b>                     | The air conditioning isn't cooling.    |
| <b>Hay una gotera en el techo.</b>            | There's a leak in the roof.            |
| <b>El inodoro no funciona.</b>                | The toilet doesn't work.               |
| <b>¿Puede arreglarlo?</b>                     | Can you fix it?                        |
| <b>¿Cuánto cobra?</b>                         | How much do you charge?                |
| <b>¿Puede venir hoy / mañana?</b>             | Can you come today / tomorrow?         |
| <b>¿A qué hora?</b>                           | At what time?                          |

## Getting around

| Spanish                                           | English                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>¿Está libre?</b>                               | Are you free? (taxi)           |
| <b>Al Hospital Paitilla, por favor.</b>           | To Paitilla Hospital, please.  |
| <b>¿Cuánto es hasta...?</b>                       | How much is it to...?          |
| <b>Aquí está bien. Gracias.</b>                   | Here is fine. Thank you.       |
| <b>¿Dónde está la parada del bus / del Metro?</b> | Where is the bus / Metro stop? |
| <b>Un taxi, por favor.</b>                        | A taxi, please.                |

## Neighbors and small talk

| Spanish                                                               | English                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Somos vecinos. Vivimos en...</b>                                   | We're neighbors. We live in...                           |
| <b>¿Me puede recomendar un buen dentista / restaurante / plomero?</b> | Can you recommend a good dentist / restaurant / plumber? |
| <b>Está muy rico el café.</b>                                         | This coffee is really good.                              |
| <b>¡Qué calor!</b>                                                    | So hot!                                                  |
| <b>Que descanse.</b>                                                  | Rest well. (a warm evening goodbye)                      |

## Emergencies

| Spanish                          | English                |
|----------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>¡Ayuda, por favor!</b>        | Help, please!          |
| <b>Llame a una ambulancia.</b>   | Call an ambulance.     |
| <b>Necesito un médico ahora.</b> | I need a doctor now.   |
| <b>Me siento muy mal.</b>        | I feel very ill.       |
| <b>Hubo un accidente.</b>        | There was an accident. |
| <b>Policía, por favor.</b>       | Police, please.        |

### 911 works in Panama

You can dial 911 for police, fire, and ambulance. If you can, also tell someone nearby: **Llame al nueve once, por favor.**

## KEEP THIS PAGE

# Cheat sheets

*The whole booklet in a few little boxes. Take a photo of this page.*

## Ser vs. estar vs. hay

| Use          | When                               | Example                                             |
|--------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>ser</b>   | who / what / origin / time / job   | <b>Soy jubilado. Es martes. Somos de Ohio.</b>      |
| <b>estar</b> | where / how you feel / open-closed | <b>Estoy en David. Está cerrado. Estoy cansado.</b> |
| <b>hay</b>   | there is / there are               | <b>¿Hay un cajero cerca?</b>                        |

## Two pasts

| If English can say...      | Use        | Example                                        |
|----------------------------|------------|------------------------------------------------|
| I did it (and it finished) | snapshot   | <b>Ayer fui al médico. Comí pescado.</b>       |
| I used to / I was -ing     | background | <b>Cuando vivía en Florida... Hacía calor.</b> |

## The sentence machines

| Start with                     | Add                | You get                                       |
|--------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Quiero...</b>               | a noun or a verb   | <b>Quiero agua. Quiero pagar.</b>             |
| <b>Necesito...</b>             | a noun or a verb   | <b>Necesito ayuda. Necesito descansar.</b>    |
| <b>¿Puede...?</b>              | a verb             | <b>¿Puede repetir? ¿Puede ayudarme?</b>       |
| <b>Tengo que...</b>            | a verb             | <b>Tengo que ir al banco.</b>                 |
| <b>Voy a...</b>                | a verb             | <b>Voy a llamar mañana.</b>                   |
| <b>Me gusta / Me gustan...</b> | the thing you like | <b>Me gusta el café. Me gustan las islas.</b> |
| <b>¿Dónde está...?</b>         | a place or thing   | <b>¿Dónde está la caja?</b>                   |
| <b>¿Cuánto cuesta...?</b>      | a thing            | <b>¿Cuánto cuesta esto?</b>                   |
| <b>Busco a...</b>              | a person           | <b>Busco a María. (things skip the a)</b>     |

Tricky gender, with the article: **el día, el mapa, el problema, el agua, la mano, la foto.**

## POCKET PAGE

# If you only carry one page

*Fold this. Keep it in your wallet. Point at a line if the words will not come.*

| Spanish                         | English                  | Spanish                           | English                     |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| <b>Más despacio, por favor.</b> | A little slower, please. | <b>No hablo español muy bien.</b> | I don't speak Spanish well. |
| <b>¿Me puede ayudar?</b>        | Can you help me?         | <b>¿Habla inglés?</b>             | Do you speak English?       |
| <b>¿Cuánto cuesta?</b>          | How much is it?          | <b>Quiero esto, por favor.</b>    | I want this, please.        |
| <b>¿Dónde está el baño?</b>     | Where is the bathroom?   | <b>Tengo una cita.</b>            | I have an appointment.      |
| <b>Me duele aquí.</b>           | It hurts here.           | <b>Se fue la luz / el agua.</b>   | The power / water went out. |
| <b>¿Puede repetir?</b>          | Can you repeat that?     | <b>Gracias. / Por favor.</b>      | Thank you. / Please.        |
| <b>Que le vaya bien.</b>        | Take care.               | <b>Llame a una ambulancia.</b>    | Call an ambulance.          |

## Ánimo. You've got this.

911 works in Panama. Say **Llame al nueve once, por favor.** Use **usted** with people you don't know well. Close enough is plenty.